

## Self-awareness



Self-awareness grants us a unique perspective on reality, but we must recognize that it is entirely personal and subjective.

Heidegger remained a very influential lecturer until he was discredited by his involvement with the Nazi party in the 1930s. Nevertheless, his interpretation of phenomenology in *Being and Time* inspired a generation of philosophers, many of them French, who adopted the term 'existentialism'. The best known were Sartre and Camus (see [Being and Nothingness](#) and ['An absurd demand for significance'](#)) – less well known was Maurice

Merleau-Ponty, who continued to apply the systematic methods of Husserl and Heidegger's phenomenology to examine subjective human experience. Even more than them, Merleau-Ponty focused on the experience of the individual, each person having his or her own place in space and time. Because we each have a unique existence, reality can only be apprehended from this unique individual perspective. More than that, he argued, we experience not only objects in the world we live in, but also our own existence – we are self-aware. This is what distinguishes the human experience: unlike other material things, we are both subject and object of our awareness.